FUNDAMENTAL BELIEFS

GOD

What are the fundamental religious beliefs of the Hindus? The first religious belief of the Hindus is in the reality of the existence of God, as the one, unborn, eternal and universal spirit, immanent and transcendent in the universe as its Supreme Being. He is the inward ruler of the universe, dwelling in all things and in the heart of man. He is the guarantee and the justification of the reality of the moral values in the universe. We need not go into the different philosophical theories of the Hindus about the nature of God and His relation to the universe and man. Suffice it to say that these philosophical theories, being free from emotional attachments, do not usually affect man's relationship to his God. The Hindus therefore agree in the conception of God in His two different aspects called the *Nirguna* ("attributeless God") and the *Saguna* ("God with attributes"). In his religious life, a Hindu worships God in the "full-of-attributes form" which includes an infinity of His attributes of perfect knowledge, power, and love. It is this God with infinite attributes upon whom a Hindu is expected to meditate and to incorporate the effects of his devotion and meditation toward the development of his spiritual life. Also with *Saguna,* or the full-of-attributes form of God, it is to be remembered that the one Perfect and the Universal Spirit is not logically expected to possess all these infinite and perfect attributes which cannot be apprehended through the limited and finite intellect of man. Nor can the mind of man form a mental picture of such a Reality. Man is, therefore, allowed to have any symbol of God for his worship. This symbol can be any form or shape—a stone, a tree, a mythological figure—representing any god or goddess which, in the mind of the devotee, is a symbol of his own God. God is indescribable and incomprehensible. This is His *Nirguna Rūpa,* or attributeless form. Though simple, this principle is usually not understood in its proper perspective by an outsider who sees hundreds of temples in India adorned with different gods and goddesses. When India first came into contact with the Western world, the foreigners called Hinduism an idolatrous religion and the Hindus idol worshippers. Actually, this is far from being true, for Hindus are the only people who stress and emphasize the fact that there can be no likeness, no picture, or no image of God, but man has to have a symbol to stand for his God.

Usually God is worshipped in His three distinct functions: the creator, or Bhramā; the sustainer, or Vishnu; and the destroyer,